Student Motivation & Engagement Survey

Findings and Recommendations for the Educational Platform

SafeX Solutions Internship, Group 43 Research Module
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Executive Summary

This report presents the findings of a student motivation and engagement survey conducted as part of the Group 43 research module at SafeX Solutions. The survey collected 16 responses across undergraduate and postgraduate levels, exploring what drives student motivation, what erodes it, and what design choices could help an educational platform serve students better.

Three findings stood out. First, feedback is the single most powerful motivator identified: 94 percent of respondents agreed that regular feedback on their progress would increase their motivation. Second, perceived relevance of course material is the biggest predictor of disengagement, with 87.5 percent agreeing that they lose motivation when a course feels irrelevant to their future goals. Third, most students struggle to follow through on their own study intentions: only 10 percent reported doing so consistently. Together, these findings point toward a platform designed around continuous feedback, transparent relevance, and lightweight accountability structures rather than one built around content delivery alone.

Methodology

The survey was designed and deployed through Google Forms and consisted of fifteen questions, mixing five-point Likert-scale items, multiple-choice items, and open-ended prompts. The questions covered attendance motivation, intrinsic interest, response to feedback, participation habits, study routines, group work, distraction patterns, and preferred platform features.

Sixteen students responded in total. Respondents were distributed across levels of study, with 31.3 percent in Year 1, 25 percent in Year 2, 31.3 percent in Year 3 or above, and 12.5 percent in graduate or postgraduate programmes. Four questions in the second half of the survey received a reduced response set of ten, which is noted in the limitations section. Responses were anonymised at the point of collection.

Analysis was carried out in Microsoft Excel using descriptive statistics, agreement percentages for Likert-scale items, and thematic coding of open-ended responses. Agreement percentage is defined throughout as the share of respondents selecting either “Agree” or “Strongly Agree.”

Findings

Finding 1: Feedback is the strongest motivator identified

The item “I feel more motivated when I get regular feedback on my progress” produced the highest agreement in the entire survey, with 15 of 16 respondents (94 percent) agreeing or strongly agreeing, and no respondent disagreeing. Open-ended responses reinforced this pattern. When asked what support would help them stay engaged, students named “constructive feedback and clear goals,” “feedback and hands-on practice,” and “good feedback and actually helping to understand the topics rather than just helping to pass the exam.” Feedback in this data set is not merely a preference but the closest thing the survey identified to a universal need.

Finding 2: Perceived relevance drives engagement, and its absence drives disengagement

The item “I lose motivation when a course feels irrelevant to my future goals” produced 87.5 percent agreement, with 62.5 percent selecting “Agree” alone. This finding was echoed in open-ended answers about the biggest motivation killer, where students wrote: “Lack of clear relevance, feeling like the material won’t matter in the real world,” “It has no benefit or is irrelevant to our course," and "Lack of clear, immediate relevance to my goals or real life." One respondent proposed a design solution directly: "A real-world impact tracker showing how each lesson directly applies to actual careers or everyday problems."

Relevance in this context is not about difficulty or content quality; it is about whether the student can see, in the moment, why the material will matter to their future. Where this connection is invisible, motivation erodes quickly.

Finding 3: Students struggle to follow through on their own study intentions
Only 1 of 10 respondents (10 percent) agreed that they follow through on the study plans they set for themselves. Seven respondents (70 percent) either disagreed or strongly disagreed. This aligns with responses to a separate item on consistent study routines, where 62.5 percent of the earlier sample either disagreed or strongly disagreed that they maintain fixed study times.

When asked when they lose focus, 50 percent said mid-way through a session and 30 percent said when the material feels boring or too hard. Open-ended answers named mobile phones, reels, laziness, and sleep as the practical culprits. The gap being reported here is not one of intention; it is one of execution. Students set plans, then fall off them.

Additional patterns
Two secondary patterns are worth noting. First, students consistently asked for a shift away from theoretical lectures toward practical, hands-on, and discussion-based teaching. Requests for "more practical work," "field work exposure," "discussion-based learning," and "practical semester projects" recurred across nearly every open-ended response. Second, emotional and interpersonal factors, including "kindness," "mental and emotional support," and being "degraded" by teachers, appeared as motivation killers and engagement supports, suggesting that platform design cannot be treated as a purely academic problem.

Recommendations for the Educational Platform

The following recommendations translate the findings above into concrete design directions.

1. Build feedback into the core loop, not as an afterthought
Every learning activity on the platform should return meaningful feedback to the student, ideally within the same session. This means moving beyond correct-or-incorrect scoring toward brief, constructive explanations of what the student got right, what they missed, and what to try next. Where automated feedback is not feasible, the platform should surface peer or instructor feedback within a defined turnaround window rather than leaving students uncertain.

2. Make relevance visible at the point of learning
Each course, module, and lesson should carry a short, plain-language answer to the question "why does this matter?" presented before the content itself, not buried in a syllabus. The "real-world impact tracker" proposed by one respondent captures this well: a lightweight indicator showing which careers, roles, or everyday tasks a given lesson feeds into. The goal is to remove the ambiguity that drives students to disengage the moment content feels abstract.

3. Support execution, not only intention, through accountability structures
To close the gap between what students plan to do and what they actually do, the platform should offer lightweight accountability features. Micro-goal tracking, streak building, small study groups, and peer check-ins were all named by respondents as features they would find helpful. These do not replace intrinsic motivation but scaffold it during the moments where it typically breaks down (mid-session, or when material feels hard).

4. Prioritise interactive and discussion-based content formats
Interactive and hands-on activities and smaller discussion groups tied as the most-requested engagement factors, each selected by 50 percent of respondents. The platform's content strategy

should reflect this: fewer long-form passive lectures, more short interactive segments, discussion prompts, and applied projects.

5. Recognise the emotional dimension of learning

Respondents named kindness, encouragement, and emotional support as material to their engagement, and reported that harsh or dismissive feedback actively damaged their motivation. The platform's tone, notification language, and instructor guidance should reflect this: constructive over corrective, encouraging over evaluative, especially in early stages of a course.

Limitations and Suggestions for Further Research

Several limitations should be noted. The sample of sixteen respondents is small and skewed toward undergraduate students, and cannot be treated as representative of the broader student population. Response volume also dropped from sixteen to ten in the second half of the form, which may introduce non-response bias in those items. The survey was self-reported, which is subject to social-desirability effects, particularly on items about consistency and participation. Finally, the study is cross-sectional and does not capture how motivation shifts across a semester or academic year.

Further work could expand the sample across institutions, add a longitudinal component to track motivation over time, and test the specific features proposed here through short user-research interviews before development begins.

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